

King's Indian and Modern

The Classical setup with a controlled 9.Ne1 plan

THE PROMISE

Build the broad center, close it on favorable terms, and conduct queenside play without underestimating Black's kingside counterattack.

COURSE VOLUME 06 OF 10

SEE THE POSITION | RECALL THE PLAN | CALCULATE THE MOVE

What this volume should change

- Reach the Classical King's Indian tabiya with Nf3, Be2, and O-O.
- Use 9.Ne1 to support queenside and central play while meeting Black's ...f5 attack responsibly.
- Handle ...Nbd7, ...Nc6, ...c5, ...exd4, ...Na6, and early ...Bg4 systems.
- Recognize Modern and Old-Indian-style move orders that transpose into the same center.

STUDY METHOD

Learn each chapter in three layers: first the trigger and plan, then the short main line, then Black's branches. Hide the page and reconstruct the line on a board. Do not memorize notation without the position's purpose.

Inside this volume

01	The Classical King's Indian spine
02	Mar del Plata race
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07	...Na6, ...Bg4, and piece deviations
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Original instructional synthesis. Move sequences were legality-checked with python-chess and critical choices were reviewed with Stockfish 18. Opening-frequency context was checked against the Lichess opening explorer in September 2026. Engines verify tactics; the explanations and training design are the course's teaching layer. Diagrams use Colin M. L. Burnett's Cburnett piece artwork as distributed by Lichess under GPLv2+.

CHAPTER 01

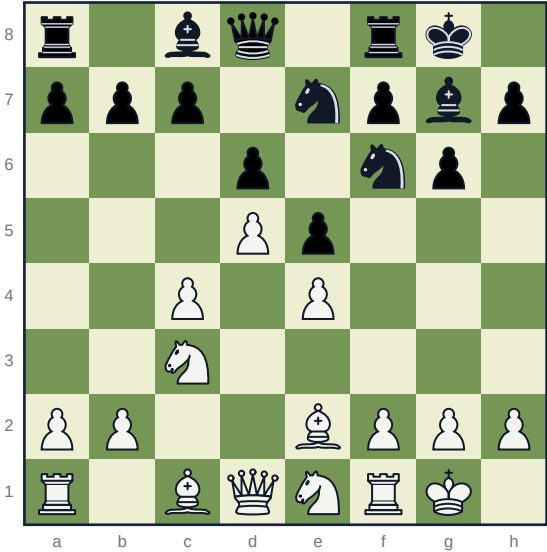
The Classical King's Indian spine

POSITION TRIGGER

Black uses ...g6, ...Bg7, and ...d6 without an early ...d5 challenge.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7 9. Ne1



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

White occupies the center, completes development, and closes with d5 when Black attacks e4. The move 9.Ne1 clears f3 for a pawn, supports c2-c5 routes indirectly, and prepares Nd3 or f3. White's spatial advantage points to the queenside; Black's locked e5/future f5 chain points to the kingside. Both plans are real, so White must create queenside play without ignoring mating threats.

White's plan

- Prepare Nd3, Be3, and c5; open the c-file or create a passed d-pawn.
- Use f3 to reinforce e4 and blunt the g7 bishop before Black's ...f5 break lands.
- Create queenside speed with b4 only when the center is stable and Black cannot exploit a4/e4 tactically.

What Black is trying to do

- ...f5 attacks e4 and opens the f-file toward White's king.
- ...g5-g4 can dislodge Nf3 or build a direct pawn storm.
- ...Nh5-f4 or ...Nf4 brings pieces to the king while White plays on the other wing.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
6...e5	7.O-O. Do not close the center until Black declares the knight route.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
7...Nc6	8.d5 Ne7 9.Ne1 establishes the main plan.
7...Nbd7	8.Re1 and Bf1; keep the center flexible.
6...c5	7.d5 and use the Benoni-style closed-center chapter.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

The closed center does not guarantee king safety. Pawn chains show direction, but the side whose pieces arrive first decides the attack.

MEMORY HOOK

Close with d5, reroute Ne1, secure e4 with f3, then race with calculation.

CHAPTER 02

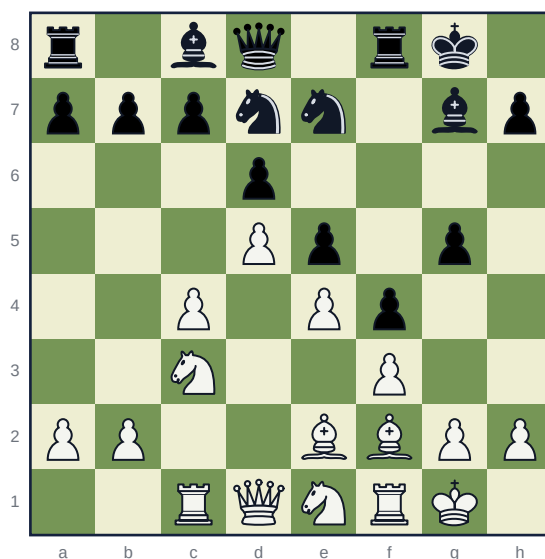
Mar del Plata race

POSITION TRIGGER

After 9.Ne1, Black commits ...Nd7 and ...f5 while White prepares the queenside break.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7 9. Ne1 Nd7 10. Be3 f5 11. f3 f4 12. Bf2 g5 13. Rc1



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The pawn chains point in opposite directions. White's Rc1 supports c5 and queenside files; Black's ...g5-g4 attacks the king. White should not waste tempi on slow prophylaxis that does not change Black's attack. Instead, calculate the point where c5, Nb5, or b4 opens lines. Defensive moves such as Kh1, Nd3, and g4 may be necessary when they directly remove a tactic.

White's plan

- Use Rc1, Nd3, c5, and b4 to open files before Black's attack becomes decisive.
- Consider Nb5 after c5 to attack c7/d6 and create a passed pawn.
- Defend concretely: move the king or close a file only when a specific Black sacrifice requires it.

What Black is trying to do

- ...g4 attacks f3 and may open the g-file after hxg3 or fxg3.
- ...Ng6 and ...Nf6-h5-f4 bring pieces to the dark squares near the king.
- Sacrifices on g3, h3, or f2 can be sound even when Black is materially behind on the queenside.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
...f4	Bf2 preserves the bishop and clears e3 for a knight or queen.
...g5	Rc1 accelerates c5; do not wait for the pawn storm.
...Ng6	Nd3 and c5; challenge d6 and create queenside penetration.
...g4	Calculate fxg4, Kh1, or Nd3; choose the move that removes the actual tactical threat.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not count queenside pawns while your king is being attacked. Every c-file success must be compared with Black's forcing checks, captures, and threats.

MEMORY HOOK

In the race, count tempi and forcing moves, not territory.

CHAPTER 03

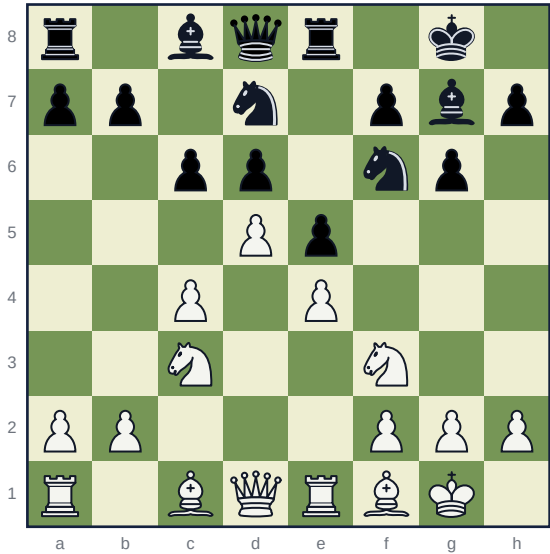
7...Nbd7 flexible system

POSITION TRIGGER

Black develops the queen knight to d7 instead of c6 and keeps the center flexible.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nbd7 8. Re1 c6 9. Bf1 Re8 10. d5



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

Re1 supports e4 and Bf1 protects the king while clearing e2 for the rook/queen. White delays d5 until Black's ...c6 reveals the structure. After closing, White can use b4 and c5; if the center remains open, Be3 and Qd2 improve development. The knight on d7 supports ...e5 and ...c5 but can block the c8 bishop.

White's plan

- Use Re1 and Bf1 to overprotect e4 and reduce tactics on the long diagonal.
- Close with d5 after ...c6 when queenside expansion gains a stable target.
- Use Rb1, b4, and c5 once the center is fixed.

What Black is trying to do

- ...c6 prepares ...d5 or supports a queenside response to d5.
- ...Re8 increases e4 pressure and may prepare ...exd4.
- ...Nh5 and ...f5 still create kingside play despite the flexible knight route.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
7...Nbd7	8.Re1 c6 9.Bf1 builds a resilient center.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
...c6	10.d5 fixes space and points play toward b4/c5.
...exd4	Nxd4 and use central activity; do not recapture automatically with the queen.
...Nh5	g3 or Be3 according to whether ...Nf4 is a concrete threat.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not close d5 before checking whether Black can answer ...c6 and ...cxd5 with improved piece play. The timing creates the advantage.

MEMORY HOOK

Nbd7: reinforce e4, wait for ...c6, then close on your terms.

CHAPTER 04

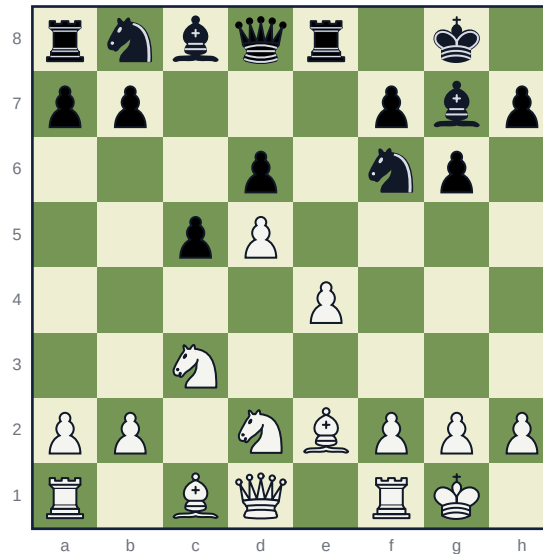
Early ...c5 and Benoni transposition

POSITION TRIGGER

Black challenges the center with ...c5 before or instead of ...e5.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 c5 7. d5 e6 8. O-O exd5 9. cxd5 Re8 10. Nd2



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The position becomes a Modern Benoni with White's bishop already on e2. White's space comes from d5/e4; Black attacks through ...b5 and ...f5. Nd2 supports c4/e4 and reroutes to c4. The course's Benoni rules apply: restrain ...b5 when possible, prepare e5 or b4, and keep the dark-squared bishop useful.

White's plan

- Use O-O, Nd2-c4, and a4 to slow ...b5.
- Prepare e5 when it opens lines and creates a passed d-pawn.
- Use b4 only when a4 and piece support prevent Black from seizing the open files first.

What Black is trying to do

- ...b5 is Black's main queenside break and source of activity.
- ...f5 attacks the broad center and can open the f-file.
- ...Bg4 or ...Na6-c7 may exchange defenders and support the breaks.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
6...c5	7.d5 keeps the space advantage.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
7...e6	8.O-O exd5 9.cxd5 and use the Benoni map.
...b5	Meet with cxb5 only if the a-file and a6 pawn become usable targets.
...f5	Use exf5 or e5 based on whether opening the g7 bishop helps Black more.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Opening names change, but the pawn skeleton decides the plan. Once c-pawns exchange and White has d5/e4, consult the Benoni structure.

MEMORY HOOK

KID plus ...c5 becomes Benoni: a4, Nd2-c4, restrain ...b5.

Black exchanges on d4

Black releases the e5 tension with ...exd4 before White closes the center.

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O exd4 8. Nxd4 Re8 9. f3 c6 10. Be3



The exchange gives White an open center and a knight on d4 while Black pressures e4. f3 is justified because it protects e4 and supports Be3/Qd2. White may use Qd2 and Rad1 or expand on the queenside. Black seeks ...d5 to equalize completely, so White should maintain control of d5 and complete development efficiently.

- Recapture Nxd4 to centralize a piece and preserve the c-pawn.
- Use f3, Be3, and Qd2 to secure e4 and control d5.
- Place rooks on d1/e1 and prevent ...d5 from arriving with tempo.

- ...Re8 increases pressure on e4.
- ...c6 prepares ...d5 and gives the queen a5/c7 squares.
- ...d5, if achieved safely, dissolves White's center and frees the g7 bishop.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
7...exd4	8.Nxd4. Centralize and keep c4.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
8...Re8	9.f3 protects e4 and prepares Be3.
...c6	Be3/Qd2 and control d5 with pieces.
...d5	Calculate cxd5 or exd5; prevent Black from freeing every piece without cost.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

f3 is a structural move, so monitor the a7-g1 diagonal and king safety. It is correct because the center is open and e4 needs support.

MEMORY HOOK

Open center: Nxd4, secure e4, and make ...d5 difficult.

CHAPTER 06

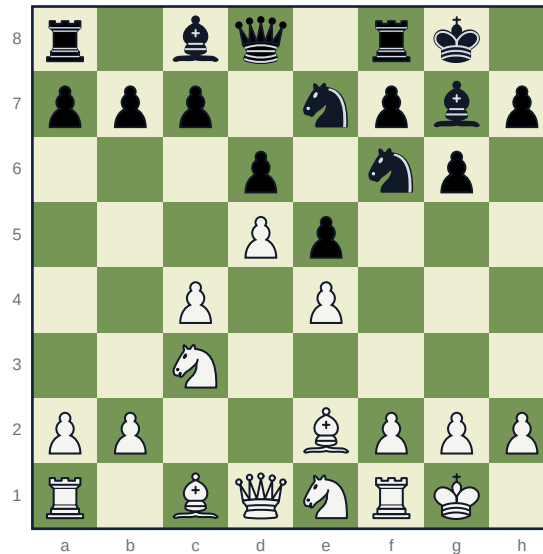
Early ...Nc6 and Panno-style development

POSITION TRIGGER

Black develops ...Nc6 before ...e5 and may use ...a6, ...Rb8, or ...Bg4.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 Nc6 7. O-O e5 8. d5 Ne7 9. Ne1



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

When ...e5 follows, the line returns to the Classical spine. If Black delays ...e5 for ...a6 and ...Rb8, White can use Be3, Qd2, and d5 or Rb1/b4 depending on the center. The knight on c6 pressures d4 but also blocks the c-pawn, so White should avoid releasing central tension without gaining something.

White's plan

- If ...e5 appears, close d5 and use the standard Ne1 plan.
- If ...a6/...Rb8 appear first, develop Be3/Qd2 and consider d5 before ...e5 gains ideal support.
- Use Rb1 and b4 only after castling and checking ...Ng4 tactics against Be3.

What Black is trying to do

- ...a6 and ...Rb8 prepare ...b5 counterplay.
- ...Bg4 can exchange Nf3 and weaken control of d4/e5.
- ...e5 transposes to the main closed center with a useful ...Nc6 already included.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
6...Nc6	7.O-O. Keep the center until Black declares ...e5 or ...a6.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
7...e5	8.d5 Ne7 9.Ne1: main plan.
7...a6	8.Be3 Rb8 9.Qd2; watch ...Ng4 before b4.
...Bg4	Be3 or d5; avoid weakening f-pawns while the king is exposed.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not confuse a developing ...Nc6 with a commitment to the main line. Wait for ...e5 before closing d5 automatically.

MEMORY HOOK

Nc6 alone: castle and wait; ...e5 makes the main spine.

CHAPTER 07

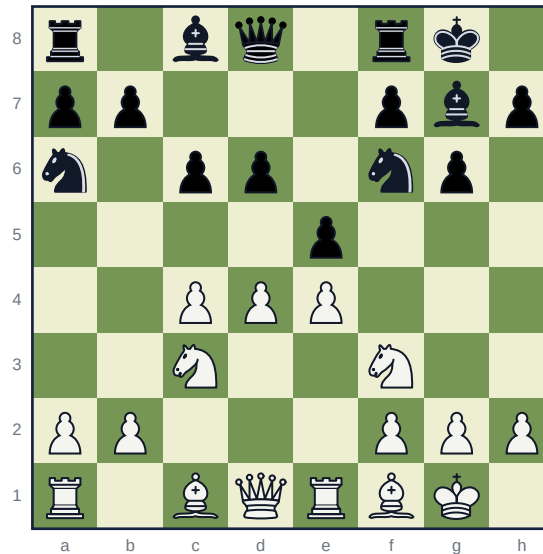
...Na6, ...Bg4, and piece deviations

POSITION TRIGGER

Black develops a piece to an unusual square while keeping the King's Indian pawn shell.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 Na6 7. O-O e5 8. Re1 c6 9. Bf1



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The ...Na6 knight often heads to c5 or supports ...c6. White uses the flexible Re1/Bf1 scheme and decides d5 after Black's center is clear. Against ...Bg4, Be3 or h3 can question the bishop, but White should not create kingside weaknesses unless the exchange matters. Minor-piece deviations rarely change the broad center; they change one tactical detail in the timing of d5 or e4 support.

White's plan

- Use Re1/Bf1 to make e4 durable while the black knight reroutes.
- Control c5 with Be3 or b4 only after the center is fixed.
- Against ...Bg4, choose Be3/Qd2 or h3 based on whether the bishop exchange helps Black's pressure on d4.

What Black is trying to do

- ...Nc5 attacks e4 and may force a passive defense.
- ...Bg4 can exchange the f3 knight, an important e5/d4 defender.
- ...c6 and ...e5 can transpose to the Nbd7 flexible system.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
6...Na6	7.O-O e5 8.Re1; reinforce before deciding d5.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
...Nc5	Bf1 or Qc2 protects e4 without damaging the pawn structure.
...Bg4	Be3 or h3; ask whether exchanging Nf3 changes central control.
...c6	Bf1 and d5 when the closed center favors queenside space.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not memorize a separate repertoire for every knight square. Preserve e4, complete development, and classify the final pawn center.

MEMORY HOOK

Piece deviation changes tactics; pawn center still chooses the plan.

CHAPTER 08

Modern Defense move orders

POSITION TRIGGER

Black begins 1...g6 or 1...d6 and delays ...Nf6, allowing a broad center.

Your anchor line

1. d4 g6 2. c4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. e4 Nf6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

White builds the same d4/e4/c4 center and transposes when ...Nf6 and ...e5 appear. If Black delays ...Nf6, White may use Be3, Qd2, and f3, but the course favors ordinary Nf3 development to keep move orders unified. Against an early ...c5, advance d5 and use Benoni plans. The absence of ...Nf6 can make e5 possible for White, but only when it cannot be undermined immediately.

White's plan

- Build Nc3, e4, Nf3, and Be2; castle before launching a pawn storm.
- Transpose to the King's Indian after ...Nf6, ...d6, and ...e5.
- Against ...c5, use d5 and the Benoni structure; against ...e5, keep the center flexible until development is complete.

What Black is trying to do

- ...c5 attacks the broad center and seeks Benoni play.
- ...e5 may invite d5 but can also prepare ...exd4 and central pressure.
- ...Bg4 and ...Nc6 develop against d4/e5 while White's center is extended.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
1...g6	2.c4 Bg7 3.Nc3 d6 4.e4: occupy the center.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
...Nf6	Nf3 and Be2; transpose to the Classical King's Indian.
...c5	d5 and use Benoni rules.
...e5 without ...Nf6	Nf3 and Be2; close d5 only when the queenside plan is ready.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

A large center is a responsibility. Every extra pawn move must be followed by rapid development because Black's strategy is to attack the center.

MEMORY HOOK

Occupy with d4-c4-e4, develop, then classify ...e5 or ...c5.

Repertoire Test

For every position, name the opening branch, state your strategic objective, and choose a move. The answer is not only a move: it is a move attached to a reason.

TEST 01 | Main tabiya

Which repertoire move begins the controlled plan, and what two ideas does it support?



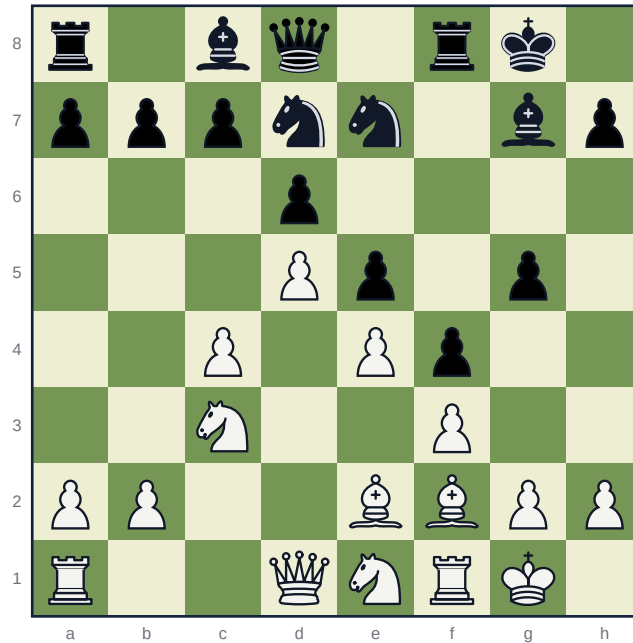
Position reached by: 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 02 | The race

What is White's practical response to Black's pawn storm?



Position reached by: 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7 9. Ne1 Nd7 10. Be3 f5 11. f3 f4 12. Bf2 g5

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 03 | Transposition signal

Which structure now governs the plan?



Position reached by: 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 c5 7. d5 e6 8. O-O exd5 9. cxd5

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 04 | Open center

What is the repertoire recapture and the central priority?



Position reached by: 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O exd4

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

Repertoire Test - Answers

TEST 01 | Main tabiya

Play 9.Ne1. It clears f3 for a pawn that secures e4 and reroutes the knight toward d3, where it supports c5 and queenside play.

TEST 02 | The race

Use 13.Rc1 and accelerate c5. Defensive moves are chosen only for concrete threats; White's counterplay must open files before Black's pieces arrive.

TEST 03 | Transposition signal

This is a Modern Benoni structure. Use a4 to slow ...b5, Nd2-c4, and prepare e5 or b4. The opening label is less important than the d5/e4 versus d6 structure.

TEST 04 | Open center

Play 8.Nxd4. Then f3, Be3, and Qd2 secure e4 and control d5. Black's freeing ...d5 break is the main strategic resource to restrain.

One-Page Recall Card

Cover the right column. Read the trigger and say the memory hook. Then cover the left column and reconstruct which position produces that hook.

Black uses ...g6, ...Bg7, and ...d6 without an early ...d5 challenge.	Close with d5, reroute Ne1, secure e4 with f3, then race with calculation.
After 9.Ne1, Black commits ...Nd7 and ...f5 while White prepares the queenside break.	In the race, count tempi and forcing moves, not territory.
Black develops the queen knight to d7 instead of c6 and keeps the center flexible.	Nbd7: reinforce e4, wait for ...c6, then close on your terms.
Black challenges the center with ...c5 before or instead of ...e5.	KID plus ...c5 becomes Benoni: a4, Nd2-c4, restrain ...b5.
Black releases the e5 tension with ...exd4 before White closes the center.	Open center: Nxd4, secure e4, and make ...d5 difficult.
Black develops ...Nc6 before ...e5 and may use ...a6, ...Rb8, or ...Bg4.	Nc6 alone: castle and wait; ...e5 makes the main spine.
Black develops a piece to an unusual square while keeping the King's Indian pawn shell.	Piece deviation changes tactics; pawn center still chooses the plan.
Black begins 1...g6 or 1...d6 and delays ...Nf6, allowing a broad center.	Occupy with d4-c4-e4, develop, then classify ...e5 or ...c5.

SPACED REVIEW

Review today, tomorrow, after three days, after one week, and after one month. A chapter graduates only when you can reconstruct its anchor line and explain its plan without looking.

GAME TRANSFER

After every serious game, locate the first position where your memory ended. Study from that exact fork. This turns the repertoire into a living system while keeping the PDFs as the stable foundation.